

Rider on the STORM

The tribal unrest in Kandhamal has become the biggest political crisis for Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik, one of India's most popular politicians. He continues to challenge politics-as-usual

■ By S. Prasannarajan in Bhubaneswar

Those who are desperately seeking the tribal-eating, Christian-hunting monster in the sleepy eastern city of Bhubaneswar are being warned: you are in the wrong place, and you are chasing the wrong guy. Still, somehow, the beastly tale has spread across the news columns that the man who has aggravated the primordial bloodlust in the lush, hilly remoteness of Orissa is sitting pretty in the safest part of the city—unseen, unheard, and reportedly unrepentant, maybe savouring his favourite vintage Bordeaux with the relish of a Dr Hannibal Lecter. However you try, you have been told, it's unlikely that you'll get a glimpse of this elusive, enigmatic creature anywhere near the site of the terror.

So, where is Naveen Patnaik, the newest threat not only to the Christians of Orissa but to the secular ideals of the nation itself? As Narendra Modi busies himself with building not an Auschwitz on the Sabarmati but car plants for industrialists ejected from elsewhere, much to the irritation of professional demonologists from the liberal-left, there is indeed a vacancy for a "fascist", at least a communalist, who is evil enough to provoke your inner secularist.

That is why, in certain versions of 'Kandhamal Explained', the chief minister of Orissa has become the villain of the piece.

He has been accused of many crimes. Had he been a bit more sensitive and responsible as an administrator, there would have been no refugee camps overflowing with persecuted Christians in Kandhamal district. Had he not been a prisoner of BJP, his partner in the state, the trident-wielding arsonists from VHP and Bajrang Dal would not have had such a free run. And he should not have allowed the followers of the gruesomely killed Swami Lakshmanananda Saraswati to parade his body across the streets, blatantly exploiting religious passions. There has been no political leadership on display in the state. Patnaik just retreated as Kandhamal burned—and the monster was born or so runs the narrative.

You have an appointment with him. When you reach the house on the Aerodrome Road in Bhubaneswar, it doesn't look like the den of a demon. It is not a house courtesy the Government. It was built by his father, the late Biju Patnaik, who still continues to be a legend in Orissa, and it's called, fittingly, Naveen

